

REIKA

TENDO

SPIRIT. STEEL. LEGACY.

天童礼華

ISSUE

14

LEGACY
CONTINUES

REIKA
TENDO

STORY AND ART BY
AKIHIKO
YAMASHITA

14: THE GROUND REMEMBERS

—— 十四：大地は覚えている ——

DIRECT SALES

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THE NEXT
MORNING.

THE TEMPLE
OF SENKŌJI.

FOUNDED
OVER A
MILLENNIUM
AGO.



THE WOOD
REMEMBERS.

EVERY CUT.
EVERY PRAYER.
EVERY DEATH.

IF I TOUCH IT—



—I WILL
SEE IT ALL.

AND I AM
NOT READY.



SHE'S
HOLDING
BACK.

SOMETHING
IS HERE.

SOMETHING
OLD.



I CAN
FEEL IT
TOO.

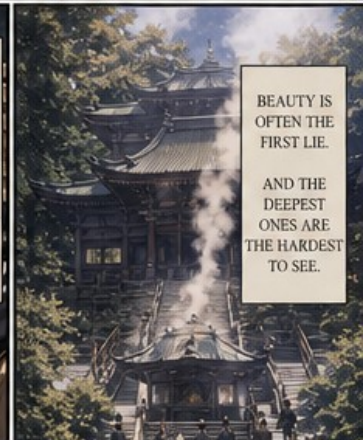
WHATEVER
IT IS...

WE'LL GET
THROUGH
IT.



BEAUTY IS
OFTEN THE
FIRST LIE.

AND THE
DEEPEST
ONES ARE
THE HARDEST
TO SEE.



THE PAST
IS CALLING.

AND SHE
IS THE ONLY
ONE WHO
CAN HEAR
IT.



1



THE MOMENT
HER FOOT CROSSED
THE THRESHOLD,

THE FLOOD
ARRIVED.

2

HER VISION
BEGAN TO LAYER—

THE PRESENT
BLEEDING AT
ITS EDGES INTO
DESATURATED
ERAS.

DIFFERENT
ROBES.

DIFFERENT
LIGHTING.

THE SAME
FLOOR ACROSS
CENTURIES.

3

HER HAND
FOUND THE PILLAR
INSTINCTIVELY—

BARE SKIN MET
OLD WOOD
DESPITE THE
GLOVE RIDING UP.

THE FLOOD
DEEPENED
RATHER THAN
EASING.

4

HER KNEES
BEGAN TO BUCKLE.

THE HALL AROUND
HER NOW MORE
PAST THAN PRESENT,

HUNDREDS OF YEARS
COMPRESSED INTO
ONE OVERWHELMING
SIMULTANEOUS
PRESSURE—

THE LARGEST SINGLE
FLOOD OF HER GIFT'S
HISTORY.

LARGER THAN THE
OLD WING EVER
ASKED OF HER.

REIKA!
ARE YOU
ALRIGHT?

THE INCENSE
AND THE CLIMB...

IT CAN MAKE
ANYONE DIZZY.

TAKE A BREATH.

EIGHT HUNDRED
YEARS.

BUT EVERYTHING
ABOUT THE MAN
WHO CARVED IT
HAS BEEN ERASED
WITHIN ONE
GENERATION.

THE BEAM
ABOVE MY HEAD
HAS NOT MOVED
IN EIGHT
CENTURIES.

THE TEMPLE RECORDS
WILL CREDIT ONLY THE
SANCTIONED BUILDERS.

HIS NAME WILL
NEVER BE WRITTEN.

HE DOES NOT
KNOW THIS.

CALLoused HANDS.
HONEST WORK.
QUIET PRIDE.

HIS COMMUNITY
WILL BE STRUCK
FROM THE RECORD.

HIS LABOR WILL
BE ABSORBED
INTO A NARRATIVE
THAT ERASES
HIM COMPLETELY.

I INHERIT
THE BUILDING.

I INHERIT
THE GUILT.

I SEE HIM.
I FEEL HIM.
HE IS THE REASON
THIS ROOF STILL
STANDS.

AND HE HAS
BEEN MADE
INVISIBLE.



THE TEMPLE COMPLEX.

AN UNSPECIFIED AMOUNT
OF TIME LATER.

THE SIDE HALL.

QUIETER HERE.
THE INCENSE... THINNER.

REIKA TENDO.

18.



PROTOCOL: RECOVERY.

I HAVE DONE THIS BEFORE.
I WILL DO IT AGAIN.

HANDS.

ACCOUNTED
FOR.

BAG.

ON MY
SHOULDER.

SOUND.

DISTANT
VOICES. STUDENTS.
SOMEWHERE BACK
THE WAY I CAME.

I HAVE LOST MORE TIME HERE
THAN I HAVE EVER LOST AT
THE OLD WING.

THE TEMPLE COMPLEX IS SIMPLY
LARGER. OLDER. DEEPER.

I MOVE TOWARD THE
SECONDARY SHRINE'S
STEPS (KATHER THAN
BACK TOWARD THE GROUP.

THE QUIETER PRESSURE
THERE DRAWS ME.

NOT THE OVERWHELMING
DENSITY OF THE
MAIN HALL.

SPELLS.
INTACT.

TOUCH.
ANCHOR.

FOOTING.
STABLE.

GROUND.
REAL.

I SIT.
I LET THE REST OF
THE FLOOD SETTLE.



OUR TEMPLE WAS
FOUNDED EIGHT HUNDRED
AND TWENTY-SEVEN YEARS
AGO, IN THE THIRD YEAR
OF JOEI.

MASTER EISHIN, A
DISCIPLE OF THE GREAT
ZEN MASTER HAKUEN,
SOUGHT A PLACE OF
PURSUIT AND SERVICE.

HE CHOSE THIS MOUNTAIN
FOR ITS CLEAR WATERS
AND PROTECTIVE SPIRIT,
AND ESTABLISHED OUR
HALL TO SHELTER ALL
WHO SEEK THE WAY.

EVER SINCE, WE
HAVE UPHOLD THE
TEACHINGS, SERVED
OUR COMMUNITY, AND
PRESERVED THE PATH.

TEMPLE
ADMINISTRATIVE
OFFICE

10:42 AM

SUBJECT: HEAD PRIEST - JIKKEN SOEN

ANALYSIS MODE: TRUTH READING
DEPTH: INSTITUTIONAL / HISTORICAL

BELIEF STRUCTURE:
100% GENUINE

DECEPTION: NONE DETECTED

SELF-AWARENESS OF OMISSION:
NONE DETECTED

NARRATIVE ORIGIN:
INHERITED
(4 GENERATIONS VERIFIED)

CONVICTION STRENGTH:
ABSOLUTE
(UNWAVERING SINCERITY)

TRUTH AS HE EXPERIENCES IT:

THIS IS THE STORY.
THIS IS OUR FOUNDATION.
THIS IS WHAT I WAS TAUGHT.
THIS IS WHAT I TEACH.
THERE IS NOTHING MORE
TO TELL.

NOT A LIE.
NOT DECEPTION.
ONLY ABSENCE.
ONLY OMISSION.
ONLY CENTURIES OF
SINCERE REPETITION
UNTIL IT BECAME
SIMPLY TRUE.

NOT DECEIT.
NOT CONSPIRACY.

SOMETHING WORSE.

A SYSTEM SO OLD,
SO THOROUGH,
SO GENTLY
REPEATED...

THAT THE OMISSION
BECAME INVISIBLE.

THE SCHOOL
TEACHES US
TO SPOT LIES.

THEY NEVER
MENTIONED
HAVING TO
RECOGNIZE
THIS.

EIGHT
HUNDRED
TWENTY-SEVEN
YEARS
OF SINCERE
ERASURE.

REGIONAL
HERITAGE OFFICIAL
40s. CIVIC EMPLOYEE.
PRACTICED ENTHUSIASM.

THE TEMPLE YOU SEE
TODAY HAS BEEN CAREFULLY
PRESERVED THROUGH
GENERATIONS OF DEVOTION
AND COMMUNITY SUPPORT.

OUR ROLE IS TO
PROTECT THAT CONTINUITY—
TO ENSURE FUTURE GENERATIONS
EXPERIENCE THIS SITE AS IT HAS
BEEN HANDED DOWN.

MID-AFTERNOON. THE TEMPLE COMPLEX
HERITAGE MUSEUM ANNEX.

KAI MORI. 17.
READING PRESENT-TRUTH
ALONGSIDE THE PRIEST'S.

FOUNDING RECORD (CLEAR)

According to temple tradition, the main hall was established in the early Heian period by the revered monk Ennin, who, guided by a vision, chose this sacred mountain as a place of devotion and prayer.

PRESERVATION HISTORY (REGIONAL OFFICE)

Official designation as a cultural property was granted in Showa 38 (1963). Restoration work has been conducted in accordance with preservation standards established by the Agency for Cultural Affairs.

*Primary source materials are limited.
Further historical verification is ongoing.

THE PRIEST BELIEVES
SINCERELY.

HE DOES NOT KNOW
THE RECORD IS
INCOMPLETE.

THE OFFICIAL KNOWS.
AT SOME ADMINISTRATIVE LEVEL.
HE HAS CHOSEN NOT TO KNOW
FURTHER.

NOT MALICE.
LOGISTICS.

THE PRIEST: COMPLICITY BY ABSENCE.

He preserves
what he believes
was given to him.
He cannot imagine
what may have
been lost.

TWO FLAVOURS
OF THE SAME
ACCOMMODATION.

BOTH SERVE
THE INSTITUTION.

NEITHER SEEKS
THE WHOLE
TRUTH.

THE OFFICIAL: COMPLICITY BY CALCULATION.

He has seen
the cost of
revising the record.
Resources.
Controversy.
Political will.
Not in this
budget cycle.

So he preserves
what is
manageable.

KAI FILES IT CAREFULLY.

TWO DIFFERENT SHAPES OF
THE SAME INSTITUTIONAL
ACCOMMODATION.



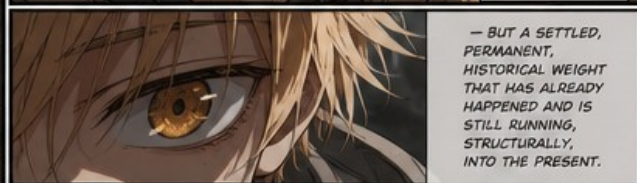
I EXCUSED MYSELF WITH SOMETHING VAGUE. TOILET.

THE TRUTH IS HEAVIER THAN THAT.

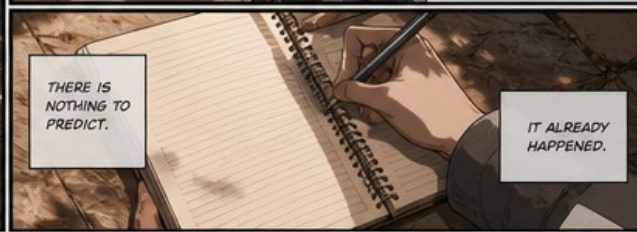


MY CONSEQUENCE-DREAD FOUND A REGISTER IT HAS NEVER OPERATED IN BEFORE.

NOT A COMING EVENT WITH A DEADLINE—



— BUT A SETTLED, PERMANENT, HISTORICAL WEIGHT THAT HAS ALREADY HAPPENED AND IS STILL RUNNING, STRUCTURALLY, INTO THE PRESENT.



THERE IS NOTHING TO PREDICT.

IT ALREADY HAPPENED.



THE CONSEQUENCE OF THE ARTISAN COMMUNITY'S ERASURE—

RENDERS AS SOMETHING CLOSER TO GRAVITY THAN DIRECTION.

THE REGIONAL IDENTITY BUILT ON THE OMISSION.

THE SPECIFIC LIVING COST OF A TRUTH SURFACING NOW BEING NOT AN INDIVIDUAL'S HARM—

BUT AN ENTIRE COMMUNITY'S DISORIENTATION ABOUT ITS OWN UNDERSTANDING OF ITSELF.



THEY'RE OUT THERE. TOGETHER. EXPERIENCING THE PLACE.

I'M OVER HERE.

EXPERIENCING THE WEIGHT OF WHAT THE PLACE FORGOT.



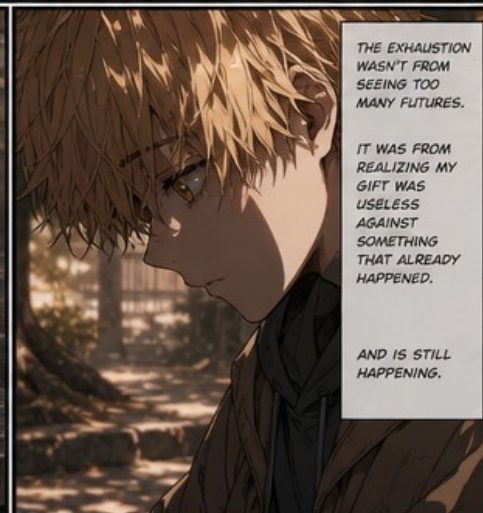
MY GIFT READS FUTURES.

BUT THIS— THIS IS PAST PRESSED INTO THE PRESENT UNTIL IT CHANGES SHAPE.



HOW DO YOU MEASURE THE COST OF A COMMUNITY BUILDING ITS IDENTITY ON SOMEONE ELSE'S ERASURE?

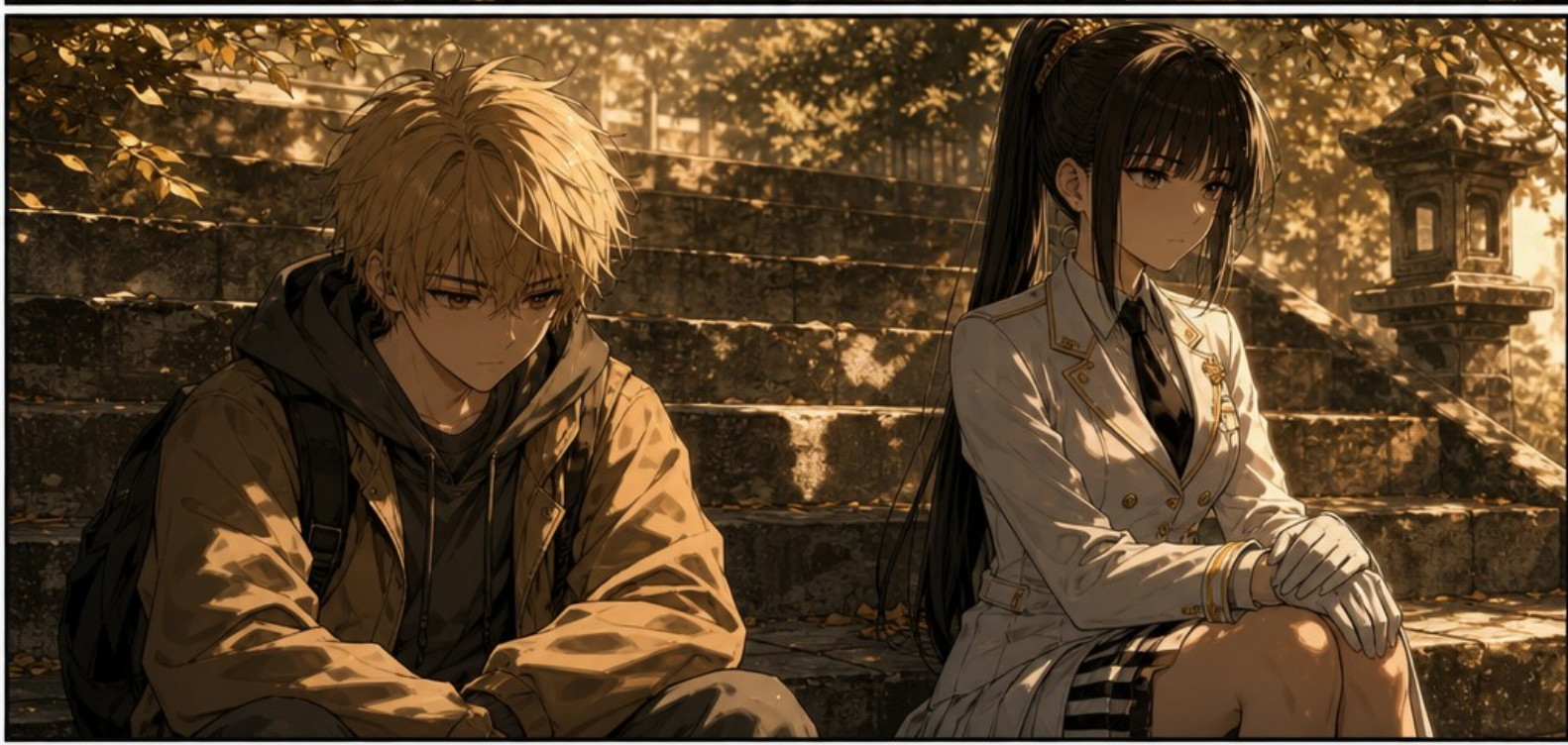
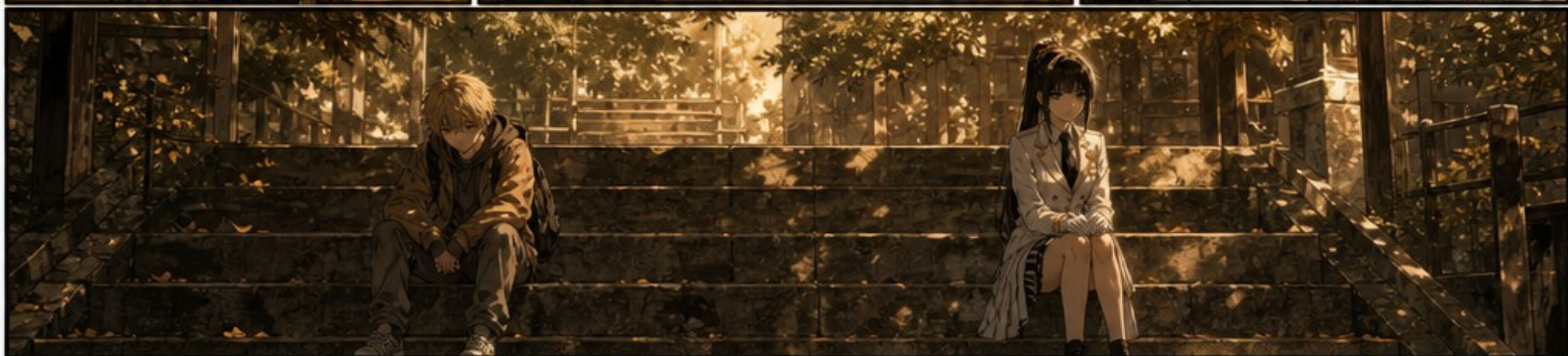
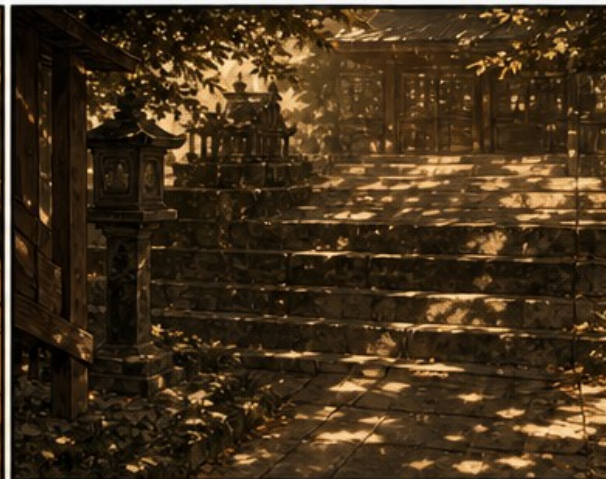
WHAT UNIT WOULD THAT EVEN BE?



THE EXHAUSTION WASN'T FROM SEEING TOO MANY FUTURES.

IT WAS FROM REALIZING MY GIFT WAS USELESS AGAINST SOMETHING THAT ALREADY HAPPENED.

AND IS STILL HAPPENING.



ASTRID BRANDT, 17

THE READER OF THE WEB

SORA MINABE, 16

THE READER OF THE FUTURE

私は
あなたの顔を
三分間観察して
いました。

あなたは、非常に
古い何かの結果を
感じています。

私はそれが何かを
知りたいのです。

…!

なぜなら、
私がこの場所で
読み解いた糸は、
異国で二年間
追跡してきた
パターンに
収束するからです。

ハッ

その言葉の
正確さ。
彼女は
本当に——

尋ねる前に
観察し、
結論を述べる。
読者だ。



SORA
MINABE, 16

REIKA
TENDO, 18

ASTRID
BRANDT, 17



WHAT
PATTERN
DO YOU
MEAN?



NOT EVERYTHING.

THE SHAPE OF IT
RATHER THAN
THE SUBSTANCE.

ABOUT AN OBJECT
MY FAMILY HAS
TRACKED FOR
TWO GENERATIONS.

LAST DOCUMENTED
IN **BERLIN** IN 1943.



IT CONNECTS
SUPPRESSED
TRUTHS ACROSS
INSTITUTIONS.

ACROSS
BORDERS.



THE WAY THIS
TEMPLE'S ERASURE
CONNECTS,
STRUCTURALLY,

TO THINGS
I'VE READ IN
MY OWN CITY.



THERE IS
SOMETHING IN
MY COUNTRY

THAT DOES THE
SAME THING.
THIS PLACE DOES.

I THINK THEY
MIGHT BE
CONNECTED.



HERITAGE MUSEUM ANNEX.
TEMPLE CONSTRUCTION ARCHIVES.

THE ORIGINAL
CONSTRUCTION RECORDS...
...THE FOUNDATION OF
EVERYTHING.

IF THERE'S
ANY LIE HERE,
I'LL READ IT.

THAT'S WHAT
I DO.

ON LOAN
CURRENTLY UNDER CONSERVATION.

REMOVED:
TWO MONTHS AGO.

NTLY UNDER CONSERVATION.

REMOVED:
TWO MONTHS AGO.

TWO MONTHS.

NOT RECENT.
NOT RUSHED.
ADMINISTRATIVE.
ROUTINE.

I READ THE TRUTH
OF THIS CASE.

THERE IS NOTHING
TO READ.

NO PERSON.

NO GUILT.
NO LIE IN MOTION.

ONLY ABSENCE.

SIMPLE.
CLEAN.

IMPOSSIBLE
TO TRACE.

NO ONE TO
CONFRONT.
NO DECISION
TO MAKE.

SOME LIES
DON'T NEED
TO BE TOLD.

THEY JUST...
DISAPPEAR.

EPISODE 6
THE MUSEUM ANNEX,
CONTINUOUS

KAI MORI, 17,
takes out his phone and
photographs the empty
display case and its
archival absence-card.

The same instinct that made him photograph the construction hoarding in Episode 4: a record of the present-erasure, kept without yet knowing why it will matter.

He does not mention the empty case to the heritage official or to his teacher.

He simply files
it, the way he
files everything.



A record of
absence.

A fact.
Filed.

In the permanent
catalogue of things
he knows and
cannot unknow.

Alongside the priest's sincere belief.

And the official's administrative accommodation.

PRIEST. SINCERE BELIEF.

OFFICIAL. ADMIN. ACCOMMODATION.

EMPTY CASE.
ABSENCE.

He pockets
the phone.

Outside, the trip group is reassembling in the courtyard for the walk back to the bus.

The episode moves forward.
Gently.



THE FLOOD
TOOK THE
MUSEUM.

SOME THINGS
IT DIDN'T
TAKE.



THERE
THEY ARE.



THE
WATER
LEFT.



THE
WEIGHT
STAYED.



SHE'S
NOT
BACK
YET.



SILENCE
SUITS
HER
TODAY.



月読神社



The main hall
shouted me
many things.

But I will
speak of
only one.



He had
a name once.

Not recorded
where anyone
would remember.

An artisan.
A carpenter.

He shaped a beam
with hands that
knew the forest
better than any
ledger.



He worked in
a season of
rain that would
not stop.

His back ached.

His palms split
and healed and
split again.

But when he set
that beam in place...



He looked up
at what he'd
built.

Tired.

Satisfied.



And that beam—
that specific beam—



Still holds the
roof up.



The priest
believes the temple
was always the
community's.

He truly does.

And the official
believes the same
thing is practical
to maintain.

Sincere belief.

Layered over
administrative
accommodation.

KAI MORI, 17
The Reader of Minds



What I felt...

was the weight
of it. Across
seven centuries.

Flat.

Heavy.

SORA MINABE, 16
The Reader of History

Every beam.

Is some truth
better left buried...

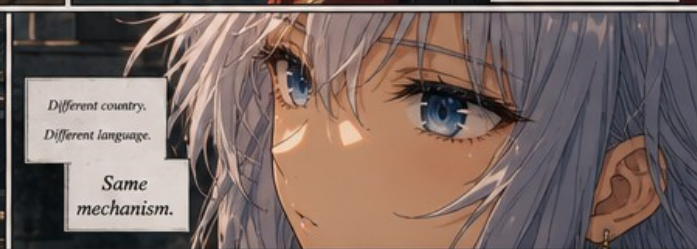
when the people
responsible are
seven centuries
dead...

...and the cost of
surfacing falls only
on the living
institution's
self-understanding?

So I ask the
largest question
yet—



ASTRID BRANDT, 17
The Reader of Stories



Different country.
Different language.

Same
mechanism.

EPISODE 14: DIRECTION



THE HERITAGE
REGION RECEDES.
THE PRESSURE EASES.
THE FLOOD QUIETS.

CENTURIES OF
WEIGHT, FINALLY
LIFTING.



KAI MORI.
RIGID. PRECISE.
ISOLATED BY
GEOMETRY.



REIKA TENDO.
THE ARMOR DISSOLVES.
THE WEIGHT FINALLY
RELEASED.



SORA MINABE.
DREAD FINDS
DIRECTION—
NOT BACKWARD,
BUT FORWARD.



ASTRID BRANDT.
HOMELAND NAMED.
STILLNESS ANSWERS.
THE ROAD AWAITS.



THE RYOKAN AWAITS.
THE KURA STILL BURNS.

DREAD HAS
FOUND DIRECTION.
THE NIGHT
MOVES FORWARD.

TO BE CONTINUED...

CUT TO BLACK.